

The Exorcism of Emily Rose

Extreme Ultra-Density Draft: Chapters 3 & 4

CHAPTER 3: JURY

Jury selection was a blood sport.

It was the only part of the trial Erin truly loved. The rest—the motions, the objections, the closing arguments—was theater. It was scripted. But **voir dire**? **Voir dire** was poker. It was reading the tells of forty strangers who were desperately trying to hide their biases, their fears, and their boredom.

The courtroom was stifling. The HVAC system, which had been broken since the Carter administration, was wheezing hot air into the room.

Erin stood at the podium. She didn't look at the judge. She didn't look at the prosecution table, where Owen Thomas sat like a stone golem in a navy suit.

She looked at the pool.

Forty people. Forty variables.

She needed twelve constants.

She needed twelve people who could look at a dead girl and see a "tragedy" rather than a "crime."

"Mr. Henderson," Erin said, looking at a man in the second row. He was wearing a plaid flannel shirt, the sleeves rolled up to reveal forearms corded with muscle. He smelled of sawdust and Old Spice. A carpenter? Or a mechanic?

Henderson shifted in his seat. The wood creaked. **Eeee-errr.**

"Ms. Bruner," he nodded.

"You stated on your questionnaire that you attend church 'occasionally'. Can you define 'occasionally' for the court?"

Henderson laughed nervously. It was a dry, hacking sound. "Christmas and Easter. Maybe a wedding if the open bar is good."

A ripple of laughter in the gallery. Erin smiled. It was a practiced smile, warm but professional.

"So, you're not a devout man?"

"I believe in... being good to people. I don't need a building to tell me that."

"Do you believe in the Devil, Mr. Henderson?"

The courtroom went silent. The laughter died instantly.

It was the question. The pivot point. The fulcrum upon which the entire case would tip.

Henderson blinked. He looked at the prosecution table, then back at Erin.

"I believe in... bad people," he said slowly. "I believe there's evil in the world. I see it on the news every night."

"But a literal Devil? Horns, tail, pitchfork? A fallen angel who whispers in your ear?"

Henderson shook his head. "No. That's fairy tales. That's for kids."

Erin made a small mark on her legal pad. A check.

Skeptic. Pragmatist. He won't buy the possession defense, but he also won't buy the 'Satanic Panic' narrative Thomas is selling. He'll look at the facts. He's safe.

She moved to the next candidate. Mrs. Gable.

Mrs. Gable was sitting in the front row. She was wearing a high-necked blouse with a lace collar that looked like a doily. Her hands were clutching a purse so tightly her knuckles were white.

Erin could see the outline of a book inside the purse. The leather cover. The gold leaf pages.

A Bible.

"Mrs. Gable," Erin said softly. "Same question."

Mrs. Gable straightened up. Her spine was a rod of iron.

"I believe the Bible is the literal word of God," she said. Her voice was steel wrapped in velvet. "Every jot and tittle."

"And the Bible speaks of demons. Of possession. Of Christ casting out spirits."

"It does."

"If the evidence in this case suggests that Emily Rose was suffering from a medical condition... epilepsy, psychosis... would your faith prevent you from accepting that?"

Mrs. Gable hesitated. Just for a second. Her eyes flicked to Father Moore.

"God created medicine, Ms. Bruner. Luke was a physician. But God also created the soul. And the soul can be sick in ways medicine cannot touch."

Erin marked an X.

*Strike. Too unpredictable. If she thinks Moore is a holy man, she might acquit. But if she thinks he failed a holy rite? If she thinks he was incompetent in his spiritual duty? She'll hang him.

Fundamentalists hate failure more than they hate sin.*

Erin walked back to the defense table.

Karl Gunderson was sitting next to Father Moore. Karl looked bored. He was checking his watch—a Rolex Daytona that cost more than most of the jurors made in a year.

"What about Number 8?" Karl whispered, leaning in. He smelled of breath mints and tobacco.

Erin looked at Juror 8.

A young man. Twenty-something. Wire-rimmed glasses. Tweed jacket with patches on the elbows. He was reading a book while he waited. *The Stranger* by Camus.

"Graduate student," Erin whispered back. "Philosophy or Lit. He's reading existentialism in public. He wants us to know he's smart."

"Is he?"

"He's an intellectual snob. He'll hate the exorcism stuff. He'll think it's primitive."

"So we strike him?"

"No," Erin said. "We keep him. He'll hate the exorcism, but he'll hate the State telling people what to believe even more. He's a libertarian in tweed. He'll acquit on principle, just to stick it to 'The Man'."

"Risky," Karl muttered.

"I like risky. Risky wins cases."

Erin walked back to the podium. She decided to test him.

"Juror Number 8," she said. "Mr... Vance."

The young man looked up. He marked his page in Camus with a deliberate slowness.

"Ms. Bruner," he said. His voice was bored, arrogant.

"Mr. Vance, do you believe that the State has the right to determine what is spiritual and what is medical?"

Vance smiled. It was a thin, superior smile.

"I believe the State has a tendency to overreach in all matters, Ms. Bruner. Especially when it comes to the private beliefs of individuals."

"Even if those beliefs lead to harm?"

"Harm is a subjective term," Vance said. "If a person chooses to starve for a cause... is that harm? Or is it agency?"

Erin suppressed a smile. *Gotcha.*

"Thank you, Mr. Vance."

She walked back. Karl nodded. "Okay. The anarchist stays."

Then she saw Juror 11.

A middle-aged woman sitting near the back. She was wearing scrubs—faded blue, with a cartoon bear on the pocket. A nurse? Or a pediatric aide?

She looked tired. Not just sleepy. *Bone* tired. The kind of tired that comes from working double shifts and coming home to an empty house.

But it wasn't her job that caught Erin's eye.

It was her wrist.

She was wearing a medical alert bracelet. Silver. Scratched.

Epilepsy? Diabetes?

And in her other hand, hidden under a folded newspaper...

Erin squinted.

Beads.

Cheap, plastic beads. The kind they gave out in hospital chapels.

A rosary.

She was rubbing the beads. *Rub. Rub. Rub.*

A nervous tic. Or a prayer.

Erin studied her.

Medical background + Secret Faith + Anxiety.

This was the Wild Card. The anomaly.

If Moore was negligent, a nurse would know. She would know the protocols. She would know what starving looks like. She would crucify him for malpractice.

But if Emily was suffering... if the medicine failed...

A nurse knows that medicine fails. A nurse knows that sometimes, doctors are wrong. A nurse knows that sometimes, you do everything right, and the patient still screams.

"Ms. Bruner?" Judge Brewster asked. "The defense has one strike remaining."

Erin looked at Mrs. Gable (The Fundamentalist) and Juror 11 (The Nurse).

She had to cut one.

Mrs. Gable was safe. She would respect the cloth.

Juror 11 was dangerous. She knew the science. She knew the smell of death.

Erin looked at Moore.

He was watching Juror 11 too.

"Keep her," Moore whispered. His voice was a dry rustle.

"The nurse?" Erin hissed. "She'll tear apart the medical negligence defense. She knows what Gambrolic does."

"She knows pain," Moore said.

Erin looked at him. His dark eyes were fixed on the woman.

"Look at her eyes, Erin. She's lost someone. Recently."

Erin looked.

Juror 11 wasn't just tired. She was grieving. It was a subtle look—the hollow set of the jaw, the way her eyes seemed to be focusing on something a thousand miles away.

"She understands loss," Moore said. "She won't judge a man for trying to save a life. Even if he failed."

Erin hesitated.

It went against every rule in the book. Never put a medical professional on a medical negligence jury. Never put a grieving person on a homicide jury.

But she looked at the beads. *Rub. Rub. Rub.*

The woman was praying.

In a courtroom.

Just like Moore.

Erin took a breath. She picked up her pen.

"The defense thanks and excuses... Mrs. Gable."

Mrs. Gable gasped, clutching her purse tighter. She stood up, glaring at Erin with the fury of the righteous, and marched out of the box.

Karl kicked Erin under the table. Hard.

"You're gambling," he hissed. "You just put a medical expert in the jury room."

"It's a casino, Karl," Erin said, sitting down. She smoothed her skirt. "House always wins unless you cheat. Or unless you play the heart."

"Since when do you play the heart?"

"Since 3:00 AM," Erin thought, but she didn't say it.

She just looked at Juror 11.

The nurse looked back.

She stopped rubbing the beads.

She nodded. Just once.

A compact of sorrow.

Erin shivered.

The air in the courtroom felt suddenly cold.

Or maybe it was just her.

Erin looked at the final panel. Twelve people.

A carpenter who didn't believe in the Devil.

A graduate student who didn't believe in the State.

A nurse who believed in pain.

It was a jury of broken toys.

"We have a jury," Judge Brewster announced.

Erin looked at Owen Thomas.

Owen was staring at Juror 11. He was frowning.

He knew.

He knew that Erin had just planted a bomb in the jury room.

He just didn't know when it would go off.

Erin smiled at him. A shark's smile.

"Your move, counselor," she whispered.

CHAPTER 4: THE PEOPLE

Owen Thomas did not gamble. He calculated.

He sat in his office, the blinds drawn against the afternoon sun. The slats of light cut across his desk like prison bars.

The air smelled of old paper, lemon polish, and peppermint tea.

Owen sipped his tea. It was hot, soothing. It settled his stomach.

He needed it.

His ulcer was acting up. It always did before a big trial. It was the physical manifestation of the sin he saw every day. The lies. The violence. The rot.

He was reviewing his opening statement.

He had annotated it in red ink. His handwriting was precise, angular. Small, tight loops.

Focus on the body. The girl. The victim.

Do not debate theology. Debate biology.

He picked up the photo of Emily Rose. The "After" photo.

It made him angry.

Not a flash of anger, but a deep, simmering burn. A righteous indignation.

He was a man of faith. He taught Sunday School at the First Methodist Church. He believed in the Resurrection. He believed in the power of prayer.

But this... this wasn't faith.

This was medieval barbarism masquerading as piety. This was a man in a collar using his authority to torture a sick child.

He looked at the toxicology report.

Blood levels of Gambrolic acid: Zero.

She hadn't taken her medication in two months.

Because Moore told her not to.

Because Moore told her the pills were blocking the "spiritual connection."

"Idolatry," Owen whispered.

It was the sin of pride. Moore thought he knew better than the doctors God had put on this earth. Moore thought he could wrestle the Devil with a prayer book.

And because of his pride, a nineteen-year-old girl had starved to death in a puddle of her own urine, screaming for help that never came.

The phone rang.

Owen picked it up. "Thomas."

"Owen, it's Sarah."

His wife.

His voice softened instantly. The prosecutor vanished; the husband appeared.

"Hey, honey. Everything okay?"

"I'm just calling to remind you about dinner. My mother is coming."

Owen closed his eyes. "Right. Your mother. The joy of my life."

Sarah laughed. "Be nice. She thinks you're a saint because you put criminals in jail."

"If she knew what I really did, she'd pray for me."

"She prays for you anyway. How's the case?"

Owen looked at the photo of Emily Rose.

"It's... heavy, Sarah. This one is heavy."

"Is it the priest?"

"It's the girl. She was just a kid. She reminds me of... she reminds me of Kate."

Kate was their daughter. She was away at college. The same age as Emily.

"Don't do that," Sarah said softly. "Don't make it personal."

"It's always personal, Sarah. That's why I win."

"Just come home. Leave the ghosts at the office."

"I will. Love you."

"Love you too."

Owen hung up.

He sat there for a moment in the silence.

Leave the ghosts at the office.

If only it were that easy.

He stood up. He was a big man, broad-shouldered. He had played linebacker in college, and he still moved with that aggressive grace. He walked to the window.

He looked out at the courthouse. It was raining again. The city was grey, washed out.

He knew Erin Bruner's reputation. The "Giant Killer." The woman who let James Van Hopper walk.

She was smart. She was cynical. She was a mercenary.

She would try to turn this into a circus. She would try to put God on trial. She would try to dazzle the jury with smoke and mirrors, with talk of "possibilities" and "mysteries."

Owen wouldn't let her.

He would keep it small. He would keep it grounded.

Condition. Diagnosis. Negligence. Death.

A simple chain of cause and effect. A steel trap.

He checked his watch.

3:00 PM.

He frowned.

He felt... something.

A pressure in the room.

It wasn't a sound. It was a change in density. The air felt suddenly thicker. Heavier. Like the air in a crypt.

He turned around.

His office was empty. The door was closed.

But the silence was loud.

And on his desk...

The photo of Emily Rose.

He had left it face up. He was sure of it. He had just been looking at her eyes.

Now, it was face down.

The white back of the photo stared up at him.

Owen walked to the desk. His steps were heavy on the carpet.

"Draft," he muttered. "Just a draft from the vent."

But the vents were off.

He reached out. His hand didn't shake. He wouldn't allow it to shake.

He flipped the photo over.

Emily's black eyes stared up at him. The bruises on her face seemed darker in the dim light. The rictus of her mouth seemed to be wider.

Mocking him.

You think you can save me? the face seemed to say. *I am already gone.*

Owen felt a chill on the back of his neck. The fine hairs stood up.

He smelled it then.

Not peppermint. Not lemon polish.

Something else.

Faint.

The smell of burning.

Sulfur?

No. Toast. Just burnt toast from the breakroom down the hall.

"You can't scare me," Owen said to the empty room. His voice was steady. "I am on the side of the Righteous. I am the sword of the Law."

He put the photo in his briefcase.

He snapped the locks shut. *Click. Click.*

The sound was final.

He grabbed his coat.

He wasn't afraid of demons. He didn't believe demons haunted offices in downtown Chicago.

He was afraid of men who thought they could control them. And he was going to make sure Richard Moore never hurt anyone ever again.

He walked to the door.

He opened it.

The hallway was bright, busy. Secretaries typing. Phones ringing.

Normalcy.

Owen exhaled.

But as he walked out, he couldn't resist one last look back at his office.

The light was off.

But in the corner... in the shadows by the bookshelf...

Was that a shape?

A tall, thin shape, watching him go?

He blinked.

Just a shadow. Just a coat rack.

He closed the door firmly.

"See you in court," he whispered.

And for a moment, he thought he heard a laugh from the other side of the wood.

A dry, scratching laugh.

Like fingernails on a coffin lid.